

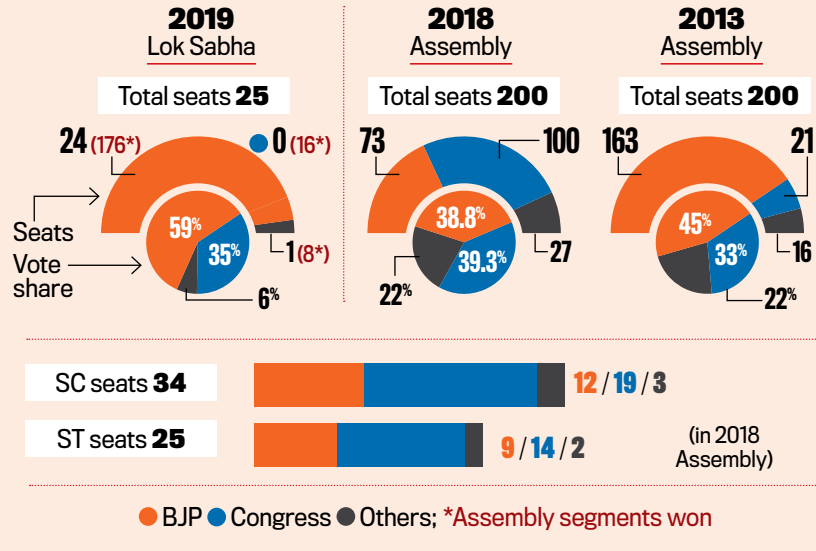
RAJASTHAN

Polling date
Nov. 25

Counting on
Dec. 3



Constituencies	Voters
200	**52,680,545**
First-time voters	**Polling stations**
2,204,514	**51,756**



the state have believed that development and freebies do not fetch votes since they keep losing elections despite them, but Gehlot's welfare policies are being lauded on the ground this time.

His critics have enough sore points to pick, though. There's the feud with his former deputy CM, Sachin Pilot, whose rebellion made the Congress government a subject of ridicule. Then there is the BJP-led central government to contend with. Union ministers from the state have been firing away at him, and the Enforcement Directorate and income tax department are trying to expose corruption at every corner.

The BJP also points to the faulty implementation of central schemes like Jal Jeevan Mission where Rajasthan began late and faces corruption charges. "People have made up their mind to vote out the Gehlot regime. His mass failure can't be covered up with campaigns," says leader of the Opposition, Rajendra Singh Rathore. On corruption, Gehlot's counter is that charges alone are not enough and that the central agencies have not been able to arrest any top official or minister.

Bypassing the inter-party sniping, the public seems more focused on the anti-incumbency against the state's MLAs and ministers. It is akin to the elections of 2003 and 2013 when Gehlot was seen a good man but with poor governance skills, someone who failed to stop unpopular ministers from contesting again. That said, the BJP has failed to make corruption a big issue so far, perhaps why the focus is on the PM as figurehead—the 'Modi is BJP' message. On the side, they are pushing the Hindutva agenda, citing for instance attacks on sanatan dharma by national Opposition members.

The Gehlot camp says their counter-strategy is focused on candidate selection, fuelling dissidence in the BJP and taking on PM Modi. But picking a winning candidate is turning out to be a challenge as the CM finds it difficult to deny tickets to those who stood by him during Pilot's revolt. He will have to somehow pacify his loyalists soon, though. Gehlot is also trying to consolidate the Muslim vote bank that invested heavily in the